



UNIT LAUNCH

The Legacy of Nonconformity

Essential Question

When is walking away from everything an act of courage — and when is it just running away?

Into the Wild is not just a story about one young man — it's part of a centuries-long debate about individuality, morality, freedom, and responsibility.

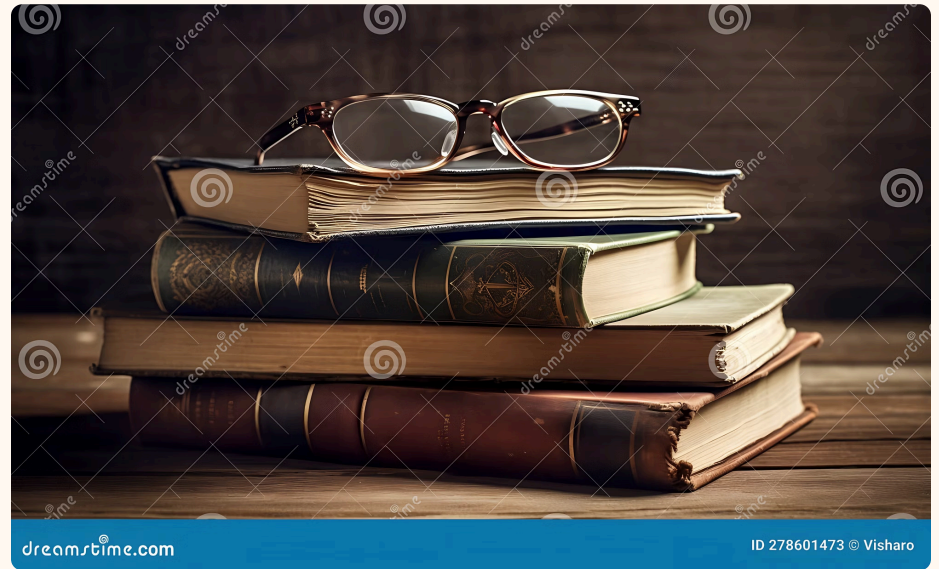
Why Start Here?

Before we meet Chris McCandless, we need to meet the **ideas** he believed in. Understanding the philosophical lineage that shaped his worldview is essential to making sense of his decisions.

This unit asks you to consider:

- Why some people reject society's rules and norms
- Whether nonconformity is admirable, dangerous, or both
- How a person's ideas shape real-world choices and consequences

Importantly, McCandless didn't invent his worldview — he **inherited** it from thinkers who came before him.



A Lineage of Nonconformity

McCandless was deeply influenced by writers who questioned the foundations of modern life: materialism, conformity, authority, and comfort. These weren't casual readings — **they became the blueprint for how he understood what it meant to live authentically.**



Henry David Thoreau

Simplicity and self-reliance as pathways to clarity



Leo Tolstoy

Moral purity through radical renunciation



Fyodor Dostoevsky

The psychological cost of extreme individualism

Each offers a *different version* of nonconformity — and each poses different risks and rewards.

Nonconformity as Clarity

Core Belief

Modern life hands us a whopping dose of two things: distraction and noise. The relentless noise of civilization drowns out our inner compass, making it nearly impossible to hear the quiet call from an inner voice, whispering us toward a more authentic life.

In *Walden*, Henry David Thoreau emphasizes a philosophy of intentionality and self-sufficiency. Here are his core beliefs:

- **Simplicity:** Stripping away superfluous luxuries to find life's essence.
- **Deliberate Living:** Making conscious choices rather than following societal habits.
- **Self-Reliance:** Cultivating personal independence, both economically and spiritually.
- **Nature as Teacher:** Observing the natural world to discover universal truths.
- **Spiritual Awakening:** Prioritizing internal growth over material or "outward" progress.
- **Solitude:** Using quiet reflection to hear one's own inner voice.
- **The Present Moment:** Finding divinity and reality in the "now."

 *Walden* (1854) — Thoreau's account of two years living deliberately in a cabin near Walden Pond.



🌿 THOREAU

📖 *Walden* (1854) — Thoreau's detailed account of his two years living deliberately in a cabin near Walden Pond.

In *Walden*, Henry David Thoreau laid out a clear path to a more meaningful life, rooted in intentionality and self-sufficiency. His philosophy invites us to reconsider what truly matters.

"I went to the woods because I wished to live deliberately, to front only the essential facts of life, and see if I could not learn what it had to teach, and not, when I came to die, discover that I had not lived"

📝 Quick Turn & Talk

- What does it mean to live 'deliberately' rather than by default?
- Is moving to the woods an act of escapism, or a necessary act of rebellion against a society inimical to authentic human growth?



Key ideas in the text:

Thoreau steps *away* from society — but not to disappear. He retreats in order to **understand how to live better**. This is withdrawal with purpose, not escapism.



Simplicity

Strip away the superfluous to uncover life's true essence.



Deliberate Living

Make conscious choices, rather than passively following societal norms.



Self-Reliance

Cultivate independence in both economic and spiritual realms.



Nature as Teacher

Observe the natural world to grasp universal truths.



Spiritual Awakening

Prioritizes growth in wisdom over material wealth.



Solitude

Seek quiet reflection to truly hear one's inner voice.



The Present Moment

Find divinity and reality in the here and now.

Nonconformity as Moral Obligation

The Thesis:

Corruption is systemic, and inevitably compromises individual morality; in other words, one cannot live a moral life while participating in an immoral system.

Key Tenets:

- Material comfort creates a moral dissonance that distorts personal values.
- Simplicity is the essential prerequisite for authentic goodness.
- To preserve one's integrity, one must forfeit the rewards of a corrupt hierarchy.

Late in life, Tolstoy renounced luxury, property, status, and even his own fame — much to his family's distress.





An Excerpt from **What Then Must We Do?** 1886

"I sit on a man's back, choking him and making him carry me, and yet assure myself and others that I am very sorry for him and wish to ease his lot by any means possible, **except by getting off his back.**"

Key idea for students

Tolstoy's nonconformity is driven by **moral purity** — not personal happiness. His withdrawal isn't about finding peace; it's about refusing to participate in systems he views as fundamentally wrong.



Discussion Prompt

- In Tolstoy's analogy, why is 'feeling sorry' for the man not enough to fix the situation?
- What does 'getting off his back' look like in a practical, everyday sense?

The Price of a Soul: Thoreau vs. Tolstoy

The Common Ground (Where they agree)

- **The Problem:** Both agree that modern society is a "noise" that drowns out moral truth.
- **The Remedy:** Both advocate for Simplicity as the only way to reclaim one's humanity.
- **The Stance:** Both believe that to live "deliberately," you must be willing to defy social norms, even at the cost of upsetting others.

The Divergence (Where they depart

Thoreau's Take		Tolstoy's Take
Focus	The Self and Nature	The Self against a fundamentally corrupt society
The Goal	Spiritual Clarity	Moral Integrity
Primary Fear	Giving oneself over to noise and distraction and wasting life.	Being a "parasite" on the poor without conscience or awareness of it
Why Rebel?	To see the world as it truly is.	To stop hurting your neighbor.
The Action	Building a cabin; observation.	Shared his wealth; lived a life of service.

📖 Answer one of these two essential questions in your notebook:

"Is it 'enough' to just worry about your own soul and your own distractions?

Are you a 'parasite' if you don't change your lifestyle to help those in need?"

Dostoevsky: On Choosing The Difficult Way

"Man is sometimes extraordinarily, passionately, in love with his own suffering."

Key idea

Dostoevsky suggests that suffering can feel *meaningful* — even when it's self-destructive. **There's a strange allure to hardship when we believe it proves something about our character or commitment to our ideals.**

Quick Write

- Why might someone be drawn to hardship or isolation?
- When does suffering become a choice rather than a necessity?



The Paradox of the Rebel: Liberation or Isolation?

The Romantic View (Thoreau & Tolstoy)

Breaking away from society is the path to integrity. The "inner voice" is a compass that points toward Truth and authenticity.

The Dostoevskian Slapback

Dostoevsky didn't hate nonconformity itself—he was a **radical** in his youth and almost died for it. However, he spent his later life warning that **dedication to a cause is intellectual pride** that leads one to behave in **destructive and dehumanizing ways**



Nonconformist are Selfish Navel-Gazing Escapists

- **The Hook:** *"Man is sometimes extraordinarily, passionately, in love with his suffering."* >
- **The Insight:** For the nonconformist, suffering feels like a "badge of honor." It proves they are different. But Dostoevsky warns that this "noble" pain is often just **vanity in disguise**.
- **The Core Conflict:** We build "walls" made of our own principles. We become so proud of our isolation that we stop being able to love "man in particular"—the messy, annoying person right in front of us.

Is Dedication to your Beliefs Making You Lonely?

- **Dostoevsky's Warning:** Idealism is a trap, leading us to turn our own ideas into **walls that shield us from reality**. We get so caught up in being "right" or "deliberate" that we isolate ourselves from the people who need us, or people who love us.
- **The Quote:** *"I love humanity... but the more I love humanity in general, the less I love man in particular."* (i.e., I love the *idea* of people, but I can't stand *actual* people).

Turn & Talk Questions

- **It's an Ideological Trap:** Thoreau says society distracts us from ourselves. Dostoevsky asks: What happens if you find yourself and you realize you've become a monster of your own ideas?
- **The Cost of Nonconformity:** Is there a point where being 'different' or 'principled' actually makes you useless to the people who need you most?

Comparing three Solitary Souls

Thoreau	Retreats to the woods.	Clarity: Finding the essential facts of life.
Tolstoy	Renounces his wealth and status.	Justice: Living without exploiting others.
Dostoevsky	Retreats into ideas, solitude, books.	Danger: Losing the ability to love real people.

Three Visions of Nonconformity

Each philosopher offers a distinct framework for understanding what it means to reject convention. As we read McCandless's story, consider which lens best explains his choices — and which reveals the flaws in his thinking.

Thinker	Nonconformity Looks Like
Thoreau	Thoughtful withdrawal for clarity and intentional living
Tolstoy	Moral rejection of corrupt society through radical simplicity
Dostoevsky	A dangerous devotion to ideas that isolates and destroys

Key Question

Which version do you find most convincing — and why? Which resonates with how you think about authenticity and freedom?

Enter Chris McCandless

Now that we understand the intellectual tradition McCandless inherited, we can read his story with more sophisticated questions. He wasn't just a reckless kid — he was someone trying to live out centuries-old philosophical ideals in the modern world.



Which of these thinkers does McCandless resemble most?

Does he follow one philosopher more closely, or does he blend elements from all three?



Where does he misunderstand or exaggerate their ideas?

Did he grasp the nuance, or did he latch onto simplified versions of complex philosophies?



Who would challenge his choices?

Which of these thinkers would approve of McCandless — and which would warn him against his path?

McCandless becomes the **test case** for these philosophies. His life — and death — forces us to reckon with the real-world consequences of ideas.

What You'll Be Asked to Do

By the end of this unit, you will synthesize everything you've learned about McCandless, his influences, and the broader questions about how we choose to live. This isn't a simple "was he right or wrong" assignment — it's about *understanding complexity*.



Evaluate McCandless's choices

Using evidence from the text and these philosophical frameworks



Compare him to yourself or someone you know

What drives people to reject convention in your own life?



Write a human-interest article

In the style of *Outside Magazine*, using story as evidence

 **This unit isn't asking:** "Was McCandless right or wrong?"

It's asking: "What do his choices reveal about how we decide how to live?"

You'll be expected to argue thoughtfully, not romantically — to engage with the contradictions and complexities rather than settling for easy answers.

Closing Reflection

Exit Ticket — Choose One:

- Which thinker's view of nonconformity feels most compelling to you right now?
- Which one feels most dangerous?
- What question do you already have about McCandless — before reading?

Take a few minutes to reflect on what you've learned today. There are no wrong answers here — this is about beginning to form your own perspective on these enduring questions about freedom, authenticity, and the cost of living according to your ideals.

The best discussions begin not with answers, but with honest questions.

